Prayers from the Ark

By Carmen Bernos de Gasztold

INTRODUCTION

When God sent the Great Flood to destroy the earth, he did so to rid the earth of sin and wickedness. The human soul had faced corruption of the seven deadly sins and God saw little chance for redemption. One righteous man, Noah, and his family was selected to regenerate the human race and God also took great care to save the animals.

The Floods came and everyone, including the animals began to pray in earnest. These ``prayers'' reflect each animal's nature, function, and fate. Each unmistakably mirrors human feelings and foibles: the self-important rooster; the haughty cat--all pray in a way that reveals essential weaknesses and strengths.

Carmen Bernos de Gasztold suggests that if indeed animals could talk, they would demonstrate the same degradation of the soul. These are their Prayers from the Ark.

Noah's Prayer

Lord,
what a menagerie!

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Between Your downpour and these animal cries
one cannot hear oneself think!

The Prayer of the Dog

Lord,
I keep watch!
If I am not here
who will guard their house?
Watch over their sheep?
Be faithful?
No one but You and I
understands
what faithfulness is.
They call me, "Good dog! Nice dog!"
Words...
I take their pats
and the old bones they throw me
and I seem pleased.
They really believe they make be happy.
I take kicks too
when they come my way.
None of that matters.
I keep watch!

Lord,
do not let me die
until, for them,
all danger is driven away.

Amen

The Prayer of the Cat

Lord,
I am the cat.
It is not, exactly, that I have something to ask of You!
No –
I ask nothing of anyone–
but,
if You have by some chance, in some celestial barn,
a little white mouse,
or a saucer of milk,
I know someone who would relish them.
Wouldn't You like someday
to put a curse on the whole race of dogs?
If so I should say,

Amen

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Noah's Prayer (continued)

The days are long,
Lord.
All this water makes my heart sink.
When will the ground cease to rock under my feet?
The days are long.
Master Raven has not come back.

The Prayer of the Raven

I believe,
Lord,
I believe!
It is faith that saves us, You have said it!
I believe the world was made for me,
because as it dies --
I thrive on it.
My undertaker's black
is in keeping with my cynical old heart.
Raven land is between You and that life down there,
for whose end I wait to gratify myself.
"Aha!" I cry. "Avant moi le déluge!"
What a feast!

I shall never go back to the Ark!
To the Ark. . .
Oh let it die in me--
this horrible nostalgia.

Amen.

Noah's Prayer (continued)

Here is Your dove.
Will she find us a twig of hope?
The days are long,
Lord.

The Prayer of the Dove

The Ark waits,
Lord,
the Ark waits on Your will,
and the sign of Your peace.
I am the dove,
simple
as the sweetness that comes from You.
The Ark waits,

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Lord;
it has endured.
Let me carry it
a sprig of hope and joy,
and put, at the heart of its forsakenness,
this, in which Your love clothes me,
Grace immaculate.

Amen.

Noah's Prayer (continued)

Guide Your Ark to safety,
some zenith of rest,
where we can escape at last
from this brute slavery.

The Prayer of the Mouse

I am so little and grey,
dear God,
how can You keep me in mind?
Always spied upon,
always chased.
Nobody ever gives me anything,
and I nibble meagrely at life.
Why do they reproach me with being a mouse?

Who made me but You?
I only ask to stay hidden.
Give me my hunger's pittance
safe from the claws
of that devil with green eyes.

Amen

The Prayer of the Little Bird

Dear God,
I don't know how to pray by myself
very well,
But will You please
protect my little nest from wind and rain?
Put a great deal of dew on the flowers, many
seeds in my way.
Make Your blue very high,
Your branches lissome;
let Your kind light stay late in the sky
and set my heart brimming
with such music that I must sing, sing, sing. . .
Please Lord.

Amen.

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Noah's Prayer (continued)

The days are long,
Lord.
Lead me until I reach the shore of
Your covenant.

Amen.

The Prayer of the Old Horse

See, Lord,
My coat hangs in tatters,
like homespun, old, threadbare.
All that I had of zest,
all my strength,
I have given in hard work
and kept nothing back
for myself.
Now my poor head swings
to offer up
all the loneliness
of my heart.
Dear God,
stiff on my thickened legs

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I stand here before You:
Your uprofitable servant.
Oh! of Your goodness,
give me a gentle death.

Amen.

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AWARD HISTORY

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